

# I HAVE LONG WALKED BY YOUR SIDE

## THE SEVENTH SEAL / 1957

### IN CONTEXT

GENRE

**Drama**

DIRECTOR

**Ingmar Bergman**

WRITER

**Ingmar Bergman (from his play *Wood Painting*)**

STARS

**Max von Sydow, Gunnar Björnstrand, Bengt Ekerot, Nils Poppe, Bibi Andersson**

BEFORE

**1955** Bergman's first hit, *Smiles of a Summer Night*, is a partner-swapping comedy.

AFTER

**1957** Bergman's next movie, *Wild Strawberries*, is a tale of an old man preparing for death.

**1966** In *Persona*, Bergman directs a bleak fable about death, illness, and insanity.



**T**he *Seventh Seal* (*Det sjunde inseglet*) takes the form of a medieval morality play.

A knight returns from the Crusades to find his native land devastated by plague. He goes to confession in a church surrounded by corpses. "I want God to put out his hand, show his face, speak to me," he says to the hooded figure on the other side of the grille. "I cry out to him in the dark but there is no one there."

**The knight Antonius Block** offers Death a game of chess for his life. Death agrees to the game, to which they will return several times during the movie, but which Block cannot win.

The figure reveals itself as Death, who has been following the knight on his journey from the Holy Land.

Having fought for God in the desert, the knight, Antonius Block (Max von Sydow), is experiencing